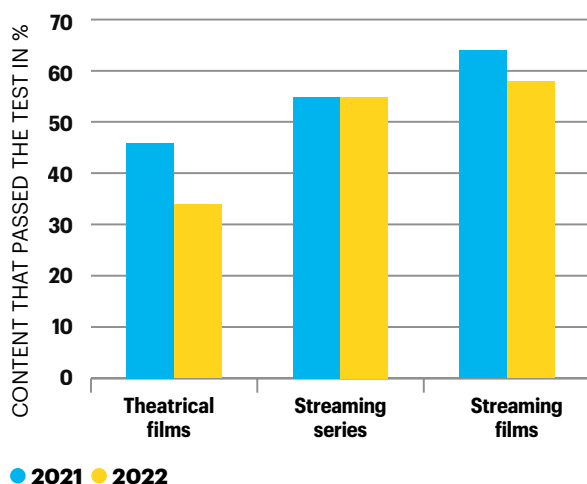


Who passes the Bechdel test?

● 12 per cent fewer theatrical films and 6 per cent fewer streaming films passed the test in 2022

● Only streaming series held their position at 55 per cent



NOTE TO PASS THE BECHDEL TEST A FILM MUST HAVE AT LEAST ONE SCENE IN WHICH TWO NAMED WOMEN ARE SPEAKING ABOUT SOMETHING OTHER THAN MEN. FOR STREAMING SERIES, IT IS THREE SCENES; FIGURES IN % **SOURCE** OMAX AND FILM COMPANION

whole production crew, besides the actress. Things have, of course, come a long way since then," she says.

Her team is now working towards having at least 30 per cent female HODs across all of Prime Video India's original series and movies. "It is heartening to observe that diversity in storytelling is beginning to bear fruit. Today, when creators present their projects, they proactively highlight the inclusion of women in the writer's room, production, and on their sets. This shift signifies a big win for me. Every incremental increase in the percentage of women occupying key creative roles marks a significant step towards a more balanced and inclusive industry," Purohit adds.

She says that the importance of diversity and inclusion goes beyond numbers. "It's about telling richer,

more authentic stories and creating an industry where everyone has an equal opportunity to shine and voice their opinions. The entertainment industry plays a significant role in moulding cultural narratives and informing societal views," says Purohit. It's essential, she adds, for the industry to authentically mirror the diverse fabric of the world we live in, ensuring that content resonates with audiences from all backgrounds.

For Kapoor, it needs to make financial sense first. "It matters to me that more women are out there, but you can't do charity. As many opportunities should be given to women if they are good at their jobs. We are in an equity industry. We are not in an industry where it's run by government grants like Europe, Australia, the UK, South Korea, China, Canada, etc.," she says.

Financial education and skill development are two essentials for women in entertainment today. "Let's [have] conversations about what is possible and not have isolated dreamy conversations. Being realistic, making change by hiring more women, spending more on skill development, [creating] safe spaces, making those bathrooms, and making sets accessible is all the work that goes into making this entire industry more female-friendly and having more women step in is important," says Kapoor.

Purohit, too, struggles with debunking the misconception that female-led stories have "no audience". "The success and widespread acclaim of Prime Video's shows like *Made in Heaven* have challenged this misconception. The reception we've witnessed unequivocally proves that there is a substantial and enthusiastic audience for narratives centred around women," she says.

To instigate change and break down these stereotypes, it is imperative to not just acknowledge but also celebrate the success of these stories, she adds. "The shift towards inclusivity extends beyond writers and directors; we are witnessing a surge in diverse talent taking on unconventional and technical roles such as lights, grips, production design, cinematography, and VFX supervision, contributing to a more inclusive and dynamic industry landscape," she says.

Despite slow growth, women leaders in entertainment feel optimistic about the future. "Everyone's waiting for someone else to change things, but it has to be me and others like me. We've only just begun. Ten years from now, hopefully, change will be visible on paper as well, and the 'O Womaniya!' report will also change," Kapoor says with a bright smile, like the one she beamed while holding her Oscar for the first time. **BT**

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